

PREMISE DELTA v0.7 • THE TRUSTING FORGERY, FIFTH CUT • 2026-09-11 (DRAFT until Stephen has read it)

Seventh delta against premise v8.1 and spine v1.4 with amendments v1.5 to v1.8. History: v0.1 and v0.2 rejected; v0.3 REWORK / REJECT; v0.4, v0.5 and v0.6 REWORK / REWORK, with Fable declining three times to attack the device and GPT conceding a front in the fourth round. Every finding of every round has been walked with Stephen and answered from the world (...-v0.6-disposition-2026-09-11.md and its predecessors). This document is v0.6 with the fourth round's ten answers built in. The one structural change is flagged. Premise v8.1 remains in force until this survives and Stephen rules.

A note to the reviewer: sections 8 to 11 record the four previous rounds' findings and the answers now built in. Attack the answers. A finding re-raised without engaging its answer does not count.

1. The device

Before (v8.1, ruled). A dead woman's accusation tears four friends apart. Her key letter: I think one of you is planning to kill me. The locker letter, forged: I know. Chapter 7: dead women don't get surer.

After (v0.7). A woman who trusted four people completely asked them, from behind a padlocked door, to find out who had been getting into her house. She said it was none of them. Within a month the four were sure it was one of them. Violet never accuses anyone. The accusation is built at Ruby's kitchen table by the four themselves, out of true things, and the true things were chosen by the one of them who killed her. Brad does not forge her fear. He forges her trust, keeps her voice and her instruction, salts the list so that four honest, frightened, competent people arrive at Liam, and writes one kind line about himself that only one person alive can know is false. What lets the four cross out her clearance is not a character reading. It is a man's back in her lane at half past ten, a back door that only they knew how to shut, and her own sentence that only the four knew where her spare key lived.

Everything downstream holds as ruled: the room lands on Liam, Margo keeps her silence, Brad vanishes off Kestrel Head on Day 60, Margo dies there on Day 214, the survivors accuse each other to the police, the police look properly and find nothing, Ruby talks to the Gazette, Ally begins.

2. Violet

Forty-four, the best judge of a hand on the coast, and she writes everything down, dated and timed. No will: a woman with a solicitor and death-triggered envelopes who kept meaning to make one, so her sister, as next of kin, will administer everything, which is the irony of the fight over their mother's house. She has money her friends know about and do not ask about, and she has been open-handed with it: eight years ago she set Brad up, the van and his first stock, in cash, on no paper, against Margo's advice. All four know that. What none of them but Brad and Margo know is that this autumn she started calling it in, for the lawyer in the fight with her sister: the solicitor's account for the hearing falls due at the month's end, and she told Brad on Day -110 she

wanted the van money by then. She said at the café once, in passing and without a name, that she was calling in what she was owed.

This autumn, two things inside her own house. Her tobacco, two a day rolled from the tin under the stairs among the paints and the garden concentrates, comes up stained through the paper; the lid is loose; the capped bottle on the shelf above has moved six inches or has not. She bins the tobacco that day and does not smoke from that tin again. She moves the house spare from the meter box to the second pot by the yard door, and tells the four on the slip, in one sentence, without saying why. And a gilded alphabet panel comes down out of her workshop roof with a ceiling board: her own alphabet, better than she has ever done it, signed with a mark that is not a name.

She carries the panel round the trade asking whose hand it is: the café, the cinema, two other signwriters. Two say yours, in a very good year, and one asks the obvious question: have you shown your lad? She shows him last, on the morning of Day -19, at the sheds, with the panel under her arm on its way into her store. He looks at it a long time and says yours, and names the R. Three yours. What she tells herself is that it cannot be his because she never taught him leaf and he never asked; what she writes is that everyone says it is hers and she did not make it. The other three never see it: they are not lettering people. Nobody in town knows Brad can gild; his boat names are painted, the leaf work at the yard was always hers, and his leaf and size come by post to his flat.

She believes someone with her spare key has been in her house. She also believes, on alternate days, that she is imagining it. She does not suspect any of the four for a second, and the reason she does not call them is not fear of them: she has nothing to show them but a loose lid and a panel three people have told her is her own, and she would rather be laughed at after she is gone than watched while she is here. So she writes it down. Her store at the slip boatsheds is one of the old brick boat stores: a bay, a steel door on a shrouded hasp, nothing visible from outside, where she kept her hull kit. It is paid a year ahead in cash to the market manager, who lets forty bays for cash to people who do not want questions asked and asks none; no receipt, and in no ledger Margo ever saw. She moves the kit to the van. **The morning of Day -19, in her book with times:** four keys cut on Lantern Street at nine, the packet's two dropped off the end of the slip; the panel, the letter and her mother into the store and the closed-shackle marine padlock on at ten, with Brad watching; the four keys into four envelopes at Civic Row before noon, to be posted after her funeral. He asks; she makes a joke about her sister. The keys are never in her house. Then she gets on, calmer, because it is out of her head. She does not expect it to be needed.

3. The three letters, sketched (Fable writes prose, blind)

The key letter (genuine; four identical copies; posted Saturday Day 12; three by home delivery, one to a post office box; the solicitor's slip in each lists the four addressees as instructed). If you've got this, I'm dead, and I'm sorry about the timing. Go to my store at the boatsheds by the slip. The padlock's new and these four keys are the only ones. Go together, all four of you, and read what's there together. Violet. Nothing else.

The locker letter (genuine; dated Day -19; Brad reads it at 07:20 on Day 14; burned in his own grate that evening with his drafts and her book). It isn't any of you four, and I'd know. Someone with my key has been in my house, or I have started imagining things, and I cannot tell which, and both frighten me. Only you four know where the spare lives, and I've moved it once already. The tin: the two a day she lies about, the stain through the paper, the loose lid, the bottle on the shelf above; I don't know whether I did that; I've thrown the tobacco out. The panel: the leak, the board, her own alphabet done better than she can do it, a

mark for a name; Brad says it's mine, everyone says it's mine, I didn't make it; and if I didn't, somebody has been in my roof. Mum, on the shelf in the back bedroom, facing the door one morning when I leave her facing the window; I've put her in here. Then: each of you write down everything odd you've noticed this year, about each other and about me, however small, and read the four lists together at one table. Then the police, with something in your hands. Write legibly. Nothing about money: the calling-in is not odd to her, it is a lawyer's bill. Brad reads it and knows what the room never will: pooled, the odd things about him name a man preparing to leave, and the panel names a gilder.

The locker letter (forged; dated Day –19 as she dated everything; what the four read at nine that night). Her paper and her pen, taken from the workshop on Day –9 with nothing else; drafted from Day –9 at his own bench from what her book said she had noticed, and conformed to her true letter on the morning of Day 14, at his bench, in two hours. Her frame, kept: it isn't any of you four, and I'd know; someone with my key has been in my house, or I'm imagining it, which frightens me more; only you four know where the spare lives. Her reason for the scale, in her voice: I don't think I'm going to die. I think I'm going to be sixty and embarrassed. But I'm putting this where it can't be got at, because if I'm wrong nobody needs to know, and if I'm right you'll want to know what I noticed. If I'd told you now you'd have sat in my kitchen with a torch and I'd never have heard the end of it. The object: I have put Mum in here with this. One morning last month she was facing the door, and I leave her facing the window. Somebody has been in the back bedroom, or I have started moving things and forgetting. Either way she is not staying on a shelf for whoever it is to stand and look at. Keep her where all four of you can see her until this is sorted. Her instruction, kept. Then, "since I'm asking you to, here's mine", bare fact only, nothing she was not present for: Liam has owned a third of the yard for eight years and lets the town think he's staff. Liam asked in March and again in July to take Mum out to the point on his boat; I said no both times. Ruby has been on nights since August and won't say why. **And the one kind thing, which is the structural change this round:** Brad paid me back the van money in October, every penny, which I never asked him to do that fast, and I put it here because it is the least odd thing that happened this year and I wanted one nice thing on the list. His one addition: not the police. I've nothing they'd act on and I won't have them in your lives over a shelf. You four can do what they won't. Her close, kept: read this together, be careful, write legibly.

What he cut: the tin (a poisoning in her hand sends a nurse to the police through any ban) and the panel (it names a gilder). What he kept that he could have cut: her sentence about the spare, because it is true and it closes the room on itself. What he added: the ban, three true things that lean, and one lie that only one living person can know is a lie. The lean is in the choosing. The lie is the only thing in the letter that is not true, and it is about him, and it is kind.

4. Brad before the night, on the night, and the fourteen days

Day –19. He watches her lock his panel into her store and drive off with the keys. He knows what she has found and that she writes things down. **Day –9.** With the spare, while she is at the slip, he reads her book of everything: the store, the padlock, the keys cut and lodged and the packet's two in the harbour, the four envelopes, the tin, the shelf, the calling-in and the date. He takes a sheet of her layout paper and her pen from the workshop. The plan is made in knowledge, which is this man. **Day 0, the last Monday before the month's end.** He comes about the money; she pours two glasses; she goes up for the book to show him the figure; the landing. In the twenty minutes he waits he takes the book, because it is his exemplar and the only record of what he owes. He rinses his glass and puts it on the rack; hers stays on the side. Out by the back door

at 22:30, lifted and pulled so it catches; the neighbour at N^o14 sees a man's back, a coat, hands empty; the book is under the coat. He is never in her house again.

He does not go near the store for fourteen days, and it is the least-cost choice for this man. Nobody else can open it before the keys arrive: no fifth key exists, the packet's keys are in the harbour, the keys were never in her house, the store is in no record the sister receives, and a brick bay with a steel door on a shrouded hasp has no partition, roof or hinge to go through. A cut, picked or forced lock is the one event in the story that makes the police look. The sheds are worked from first light, so an early visit has the same witness on any day and a torch at two in the morning is what gets remembered. His own locker in the same corridor is a reason to be there at seven, and his PO box gives him seven. From Day -9 he drafts at his own bench. On Day 14 at 07:20 he opens her store, reads her true letter, takes it and the panel to his own locker, and drives home. By ten the draft is conformed; by two the forgery and her mother are in her store; that evening the drafts, the true letter and the book go into his own grate. The boat owner saw a signwriter at her store door at twenty past seven, carrying a board between two doors, and thought her pupil was collecting her kit.

5. The room, week by week (replaces spine rows 14 to 60 in substance)

Day 14, 21:00. Torches, the padlock, a letter in her hand and her mother beside it. Margo: she's brought her mum. Brad hands Ruby the letter and lets Liam be the one who reaches. Liam carries the tube to Ruby's car, footwell not boot. Read that night at Ruby's table. The first response is relief, and then the shame of relief. Liam explains March and July the moment they are read: it had been four years; I thought if somebody offered she wouldn't have to be the one to decide. Ruby explains the nights: a roster, and she had not wanted to say she was tired. Brad says nothing about the kind line and does not need to; Ruby reads it aloud and the room is glad of it. Ruby names the one line that did not sound like Vi: the police one. Liam answers it, because he knows why: Vi and the police, the night her mother died. Ruby lets it go, and it is the thing she will tell Ally she should never have let go. They decide, four of them, that Violet's sister hears nothing until they know what they are looking at. Weekly meetings agreed. The tube on Ruby's sideboard, label to the wall because that is how Liam set it down.

Day 15. The key question, because they are competent adults, and the outward look, done in one evening. Liam answers the key because he found her: front locked, back latched, the spare in the second pot where she had told them, on the slip, that she had moved it, and not why; one glass on the side. Number 14 told him at the funeral what she told the police on Day 1: a man's back in the lane at half past ten, going out the back. And the back door. Violet's back door does not catch unless you lift it as you pull; Liam fitted it, and every one of them has cursed it on a Tuesday night. Liam found it latched. Whoever left knew the trick, and the only people who ever used that door were the people who came in by the yard: them. The solicitor has never been past her front room; the trade has never been in the house. Let in or let himself in, and out through a door only they knew how to shut. And the letter, in her hand: only you four know where the spare lives, beside it isn't any of you. They look outward, and there is nobody there, and that is the worst thing that could have happened to them.

Meeting 1 (Day 19). The lists begin. Liam confirms the third of the yard; the letter has told one truth and earned the rest. Nobody lists money: the one money fact in the room is on Vi's own list, and it is a kindness. Where were we on the Monday night: Ruby on shift; Margo at home, alone; Liam alone at the yard; Brad at home, on foot, alone, which is the truth minus the walk. Nobody has an alibi and the quiet man has the least. Ruby says the line the room needs, and nobody answers it, because answering means saying Vi opened her door at night to a stranger who then knew how to shut her back door: she thought she'd know, and she's dead.

Meeting 2 (Day 26). Everything odd about Violet. The shelf. The moved spare, and why she did not say why. Who had been in the back bedroom this year. Liam, honestly: once, the window catch, spring. Margo underlines Spring.

Meeting 3 (Day 33). March and July, again, now beside the catch, the pot and the back door. Brad: that's Liam, he'd have thought that. Ruby: Vi didn't write down things that didn't bother her. Nobody looks at the sideboard. The room hears an ordinary explanation given quickly as one given before; it hears a kindness about her mother as an interest in the back bedroom. That is what a frightened room does to the quiet man, and it is what the later chapters indict the room for.

Meetings 4 and 5 (Days 40, 47). The lists worked against each other; Ruby drives; Brad defends Liam each time, reasonably, and loses. By Day 47 it has landed on Liam without one line of the letter having said it. Margo, alone at the sideboard for as long as it takes Ruby to say goodbye upstairs: a quarter turn of the label, and back.

Days 45 to 53. Margo. She was never the estate's accountant: the sister uses her own solicitor and her own accountant. On Day 8 Margo helped the sister with paperwork, which was handing over Violet's business books, and told her the private loan book was not among them (shrug). Around Day 45 the sister's accountant rings about that book, and Margo tells him the truth: Violet's private loan book; the van loan to Brad, which everyone knew; and the letter in Violet's hand says it was repaid in October, every penny. The estate closes its interest, because a certified letter and no paper leave nothing to pursue. That call is her arrival. She hears herself certify, to a professional, a sentence she does not believe: Violet told her in July she was calling it in and nothing had come, Violet forgot nothing and told her everything about money, and the book that would settle it left a locked house the night Violet died. It is a reading, not a proof, and she cannot take it anywhere: a conversation in July against a letter in Vi's hand; a client's confidence; the room would ask how she knows, in front of him; and the man it points at is the one arguing for the man the room has chosen. **Day 54, meeting 6:** she stops arguing with Brad and stops looking at the other two. Brad is the only person alive who knows there is a lie in that letter and who can catch it: Violet told him on Day -110 that her accountant had told her to get paper. He has watched Margo since the Monday night. When the one person who can catch the kind line stops arguing with him, he reads it, and nobody else at the table can. **Day 60:** Kestrel Head, as ruled.

Day 82. After the room breaks, Ruby decides the sister should have her mother back. She tells her Violet had locked her in her store at the sheds, and hands her the tube. The sister has the empty store's padlock cut the same week. Nothing else is there. From there as ruled: Day 77 Tessa's screenshot, word for word; the withdrawals; Day 214; the review; the Gazette; Ally, who hears about the ashes from the sister, bitterly, in chapter 3, and never from the survivors.

6. Chapter 7: a suspect turn, honestly

By chapter 4 Ally holds, from the boat owner via the Tip Line and unaided, that "the young one" was at Violet's store at twenty past seven on the Monday morning, carrying a board between two doors. By chapter 6 she holds the panel from the two signwriters and the calling-in from the café. In chapter 7 Ruby gives her the envelope: the solicitor's slip listing four addressees, one a box number, and the Saturday postmark. A box is cleared first thing; home delivery came after work. One of the four held his key by seven, and the boat owner saw him use it at twenty past. The letter the four read together at nine that night had been in his hands since morning. Chapter 7 claims no more than that: the man who defended Liam every week deserves the investigation nobody gave him. The panel the town saw her carry and the letter never mentions; the one line that did not sound like Vi; and the letter's one kindness, which is to the man who had it for fourteen hours,

about money the café says she was calling in: these are why the listener believes it, not proof, and Ally says so. Proof arrives where the spine has it: the arrest on Day 333, the panel on his wall, the deckhand's papers.

7. What changes, what does not

Changes this round. The kind line for the candour; the marathon out of the forgery, Ruby's nights in; keys cut, used and lodged in one morning; the back door's trick as the pool-closing fact; Brad reads the book on Day -9 and the money has a date; Ruby's doubt answered by Liam on night one; the spare moved to the second pot and told; no rucksack; the market manager's line; the slip lists four.

Changes carried from earlier rounds. The premise device; the cold open's middle (section 12); chapter 1 packages 4 to 6; chapter 2 packages 2, 3, 8 and 10; chapter 7; the ashes for the board; intestacy; the sister with her own people; the loan open and the calling-in private; one glass; the store off the books and Day 82 via Ruby; the panel shown at the store door; Brad never in her house after Day 0; the box number; the bare key note; terminology per v1.8. Rulings withdrawn along the way: teacher's pride; the probate engagement; "the ninth"; "starter list"; the two glasses; Brad's candour; her habit of the door as the closing fact (kept as colour).

Does not change. The motive (the van money, called in for the fight with the sister; lent on no paper by Violet's choice; the book the only record). The panel (her alphabet, his mark) and the dosed tin as what frightened her into the store. Brad's PO box, dawn read and same-day swap (v1.7). His nine hundred days, the deckhand's papers, the vanish, the arrest under the deckhand's name on Day 333. Margo's six-week silence as the load-bearing lock, in the shape it had under v8.1, and her death. The survivors' fear of each other, the police look (row 25, R27), the Gazette, Ally's ten weeks. All four decisions. The notch. The two survivors' refusal to speak of what stood beside the letter.

8. The vo.3 round (ten findings; answers still in force)

Brad and the padlock (section 4). Chapter 7 not an inference (section 6). The machinery's scale (sections 2 and 3). Margo (section 5, reworked three times since). The key question and Liam's line (section 5). The sister and the ashes (Day 82). Bare fact only in the salt (section 3). Ruby to Del on Day 15 (row 25, R27). No date for the shelf. The first minute (section 12).

9. The vo.4 round (nine findings; answers still in force)

Margo never engaged; intestacy. The pool (now the back door). The fourteen days (sections 2 and 4). The fall made a killing (now the lane and the back door). Chapter 7 a suspect turn. Violet shows Brad. The sister told on Day 82. The letter dated. The panel in his locker.

10. The vo.5 round (nine findings; answers still in force)

The loan open, the calling-in private (now with the kind line, not candour). One glass. The store off the books. The showing at the store door. His own bench and grate. Packet keys off the slip. The solicitor's papers. The room never asks the sheds. Liam and the van money.

11. The vo.6 round: ten findings and their answers (attack these)

#	Finding (Fable / GPT)	Answer built into vo.7
1	The book at meeting one; candour hands Margo "it'll be in her book"; the marathon is Brad's own lie (both drivers)	Section 3: the kind line; nobody thinks he owes anything; Margo lists nothing about money; the marathon out, Ruby's nights in.
2	Margo's silence unreadable and unmistakable at once; her competent action after Day 50 (GPT); the cash trail (Fable)	Section 5: no demand, no payment, no number; the Day 45 call is her arrival; Brad alone knows there is a lie and who can catch it.
3	The key custody window (GPT)	Section 2: cut, used and lodged in one morning, never in her house.
4	The pool: the habit admits the solicitor and the trade (GPT); the trade as trusted (Fable)	Section 5, Day 15: the back door's trick.
5	Brad reads the book before Day 0; the forcing date (Fable)	Section 4: Day -9; the solicitor's account at the month's end.
6	Ruby's doubt parked for three hundred days (Fable)	Section 5, Day 14: Liam answers it; Ruby lets it go and regrets it.
7	The spare left in the meter box (Fable)	Section 2: moved to the second pot and told.
8	The rucksack (Fable)	Section 4: under the coat.
9	The market manager (Fable); the store answer holds (GPT)	Section 2: forty bays for cash, no questions.
10	The covering slip (Fable)	Section 3: lists the four addressees.

12. The first minute: the test

Two versions of the open's middle go to the three blind readers with the ruled vo.4 open as control. Version A: she said someone had been getting in; she said it wasn't any of them; she said she might be imagining it; she wasn't; she was dead; within a month the four she trusted with the only keys were sure it was one of them; only two of them are still alive. Version B brings "only two of them are still alive" and the tin's image inside the first sixty seconds. One question at the minute mark, unprompted: what are you afraid of right now. Nothing is ruled until the readers answer.

13. The new and changed facts, swept

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
The kind line: Brad repaid in October	The four; the estate's accountant on Day 45	Believe it; close the estate's interest	They do; a certified letter and no paper	Yes
Margo knows it is false	Margo	Tell the estate; tell Del; tell the room	A July conversation against a letter in Vi's hand; a confidence; in front of him; he defends Liam	Yes, and it costs her
Brad knows Margo can catch it	Brad	Watch her	He does; meeting six	Yes: the asymmetry
Keys never in her house	Brad, Day -19 to 0	Copy one	No window	Yes
The back door's trick	The four	Close the pool	They do	Yes
Brad reads the book Day -9	Brad	Act on it	He does: the plan in knowledge; Day 0 on the money's date	Yes
The spare moved and told	The four; Liam Day 1	Use it; remember it	Both	Yes

Fact	Holder	Earliest competent action	Outcome	Holds?
Ruby's doubt answered	Ruby	Follow it	Liam's answer; she lets it go	Yes, as a regret she owns
The market manager	Sister	Learn of the store	Not before Day 82	Yes (GPT concedes)
The slip lists four	Ally, chapter 7	Read it	The box number	Yes

PROMPT FOR CHATGPT (paste everything below this line)

You are the adversarial reviewer for a true-crime mystery in production. This premise change has been attacked four times and reworked four times on the findings; sections 8 to 11 list those findings and the answers now built in. Your job is to break the fifth cut, not to improve it. Read the delta above in full. Attack on six fronts. For each front, find the strongest objection you can, state it plainly, say whether it is fatal, serious or cosmetic, and say what would have to be true for it to be answered. A finding from a previous round re-raised without engaging its answer does not count; if you think an answer fails, say exactly where it fails. Do not soften. Do not propose alternative stories. No scores, no percentages. No em dashes.

The fronts:

1. **The kind line.** The forgery says Brad repaid the van money in October, every penny. Find the person other than Margo who can test that sentence before Day 60, and say what they find.
2. **Margo's lock, fifth time.** She hears herself certify the kind line to the estate on Day 45 and stops arguing at meeting six. Find her earliest competent action after Day 45 and say what happens. Then say whether a room that has just watched her go quiet asks her why, and what she answers.
3. **The back door.** The pool closes on a latch only the four knew how to shut. Find the person outside the four who knew, or the reason the room cannot rely on Liam's word that it was latched.
4. **Day -9 to Day 0.** Brad has read her book and knows everything, including that the keys are lodged and the panel is locked away. Find what a competent man does with nine days of that knowledge that is better for him than the landing, and say whether it moves Day 0.
5. **Night one.** Ruby's doubt about the police line is answered by Liam and let go. Find the second line in the forged letter that a competent Ruby, or anyone at the table, catches on night one, and say what follows.
6. **The whole.** Take the device as it now stands and find the earliest competent action by any person in the story, on any fact, that ends the episode before its time. If there is none, say so.

End with one paragraph: PROCEED, PROCEED WITH CHANGES, TEST BEFORE COMMITTING, REWORK or REJECT, with your confidence and the single finding that most drives the verdict.